

****Kernel driver kills AV**** The malicious driver disables every AV/EDR product in under five seconds, letting the password-stealer run unchecked.

** CAREER ADVICE – CERTIFY FOR THE UNKNOWN**

Ransomware negotiations demand a blend of **CISSP**, **GCFA**, and **CERT-RMM** knowledge. The LastPass fake installer shows attackers can cripple defenses before demanding ransom. If you can't see the breach, you can't negotiate from a position of strength. – **Get hands-on with Windows kernel debugging** – spot unsigned-driver tricks faster than most SOC's. – **Earn the Certified Incident Responder (CIR) badge** – forces you to document

****⚠ RANSOMWARE NEGOTIATION – WHAT MOST TEAMS THINK VS WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS****

- ****What most teams assume****: "If AV is down, we're dead-in-the-water; the ransom demand will skyrocket."
- ****What actually happens****: Attackers use AV shutdown as a cover to exfiltrate data, then send a low-ball ransom with a deadline. The real leverage is stolen credentials, not encryption. Last week, our blue team discovered a kernel driver that silently disabled ****Microsoft Defender**** on three endpoints. Within

****RECOVERY LOGISTICS – BUILDING A PLAYBOOK THAT SURVIVES DRIVER-LEVEL ATTACKS****

1. ****Immediate containment**** – run ``sc queryex type= driver`` to list loaded drivers; flag any unsigned or Microsoft-signed binaries not on the whitelist.
2. ****Forensic snapshot**** – use ``wbadmin start systemstatebackup`` before wiping the infected host; preserves the driver's hash for legal attribution.
3. ****Credential rotation**** – force MFA reset on accounts that used the compromised authenticator; the fake LastPass

**** [REDACTED] OPERATIONAL CHECKLIST****

- Verify driver signatures on every new kernel load.
- Automate AV/EDR health checks every 30 seconds.
- Maintain a “golden image” of baseline drivers for quick diff.
- Run tabletop negotiations quarterly with a certified negotiator.

****Bold prediction: In the next 12 months, 70% of ransomware campaigns will start with a kernel-level driver that disables AV before any encryption occurs.****